

Business.Net

The Six Degrees of Separation theory, by sociologist Stanley Milgram, declares that you are just six steps away from any person on Earth. Mahendra Sonje, an entrepreneur, experienced it recently. As the CEO of a software company, he was seeking an expert in Assembly language ZAT for his embedded design project. He met Ram Rao, another businessman, who fit the bill—not at a cocktail party, or a corporate luncheon—but on Ryze, a social networking Web site.

Welcome to social networking, where business deals are clinched through an online profile and offline meetings. Ryze (www.ryze.com), LinkedIn (www.linkedin.com), Spoke (www.spoke.com), Friendster (www.friendster.com), Tribe (www.tribe.net), etc, are just some of the popular Web sites fuelling this communication exchange.

In the Bible, the Tower of Babel never got constructed, but contact, communication and cooperation have been the buzzwords for centuries. Social networking is the process of connecting individuals via a one's 'personal network'. These networks then branch out, and allow friends to connect with people inside their accepted circle.

These Web sites are merely putting this need to practical use. Big players such as Google.com and Ebay.com have also joined the networking bandwagon, and set up Web sites that allow people to build contacts online without the fear of

Has the Web
netted you
friendship,
love, and
possibly
marriage?
Why not
spread the
Net for
business too!

misuse—Google started Orkut.com. So then what is their *modus operandi*?

How they do it?

Social networking Web sites build on the belief that everyone has a network bigger than they assume. This means that if you have 10 friends, and each in turn has 10 more, you know 1,000 people indirectly.

Basic membership is free, and you are given a Web page to describe yourself and provide basic information. Ryze allows you to state what you have and what you want, while Tribe classifies it into personal and professional information. Once you register, you can view the details of a person, and decide on adding him or her as a friend on your page. When your invitation is accepted, mutual contacts are automatically added as a part of your network.

There are a large number of affinity listings on each Web site. Ryze calls it its 'networks', while Tribe simply calls it 'tribes'. Web sites such as Friendster and Emode (www.emode.com) have dating as their primary agenda, whilst Ryze and Spoke are mainly for business purposes.

So you'll meet small business owners and SoHo workers, with whom you can share diverse interests as drama or Reiki. Register with a group, and widen your network. The bulletin boards of networks has posts about jobs, house and product sales, as well as new venture start-ups.

